LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

What Your Messy Room Is Doing to Your Mind

What clutter does to stress and focus, when a bit of mess helps creativity, easy tidying tricks and phrasal verbs – and what Lucy found under "the chair".



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 💬
Solve the crossword, try the five-minute week and tell us what you found!

0 Warm-up: My clutter check

fun · no points

Be honest! Tick everything that is true for you right now. 😅

- ☐ 🪑 I have "the chair"
- ☐ 🔌 I have too many chargers
- ☐ 📱 I have apps I never use
- ☐ ✉️ I have a pile of letters
- ☐ 💻 10+ tabs are open now
- ☐ 🔑 I lost my keys this month

My clutter score: _____ / 6

Guess! Can a messy room ever be **good** for you?

(a) no, never (b) yes – for creativity (c) only on Sundays

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱ 5:34**

Jack: "I lost my keys for forty minutes. They were in the fridge!" 🥛



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. Are you a tidy person or a messy person?

2. What's the messiest place in your home right now?

3. Can you study well at a messy desk?

4. What's something you should get rid of, but never do?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Then check at ⏱️ 12:56 and ⏱️ 13:51

- ☐ **1.** clutter
- ☐ **2.** to declutter
- ☐ **3.** messy
- ☐ **4.** tidy
- ☐ **5.** to get rid of
- ☐ **6.** overwhelming
- ☐ **7.** stuff
- ☐ **8.** to go through
- ☐ **9.** to sort out
- ☐ **10.** cortisol

a) to look at each item carefully
b) an informal word for "things"
c) a lot of things in one place, in an untidy way
d) to throw away, sell or give away something you don't want
e) organised, with everything in its place
f) a stress hormone in your body
g) to remove things you don't need, to make a space tidier
h) so big or so much that you feel you can't deal with it
i) to organise something, or solve a problem with it
j) untidy, with things in the wrong places



Pronunciation corner 🔊 **CLUT**-ter · de-**CLUT**-ter · o-ver-**WHELM**-ing · **COR**-ti-sol · **TI**-dy (/ˈtaɪdi/). Say it out loud: *"Your bedroom looks like a bomb's hit it!"*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) You need a perfect, empty home to be happy and creative.
- (b) Clutter can affect stress and focus, a little mess can help creativity – and small, easy steps make a space calmer.
- (c) Mess has no effect on our brain at all, so there's no reason to tidy.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

fridge · **chargers** · **ping pong balls** · **chess** · **umbrella** · **voucher** · **envelope** · **magazines**

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. "Clutter" is…

(a) a lot of things in an untidy way
(b) a type of cleaning spray
(c) a very tidy room

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

2. Your desk has too many papers on it, but it isn't dirty. You need to _____ it.

(a) clean
(b) tidy
(c) wash

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

3. "I threw _____ my old clothes."

(a) at
(b) on
(c) away

🧠 Grammar you know

4. The opposite of "messy" is…

(a) tidy
(b) busy
(c) quiet

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

5. "Stuff" is an informal word for…

(a) people
(b) things
(c) places

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. Where did Jack find his keys?

(a) in an old coat
(b) in the fridge
(c) under a pile of papers

🎧 ⏱️ 0:05

7. In the Los Angeles study, people gave the researchers…

(a) a video tour of their home
(b) photos of their kitchen
(c) a cleaning diary

🎧 ⏱️ 2:38

8. In the Minnesota study, people in the messy room…

(a) chose more apples
(b) had more creative ideas
(c) gave more money to charity

🎧 ⏱️ 5:34

9. How many apps did Jack delete from his phone?

(a) 3
(b) 31
(c) 23

🎧 ⏱️ 10:09

10. What was in the envelope under Lucy's chair?

(a) a bill
(b) a voucher for a cooking class
(c) an old train ticket

🎧 ⏱️ 18:39

🧩 **Fun fact:** Jack had **31 tabs** open, about **4,000** unread emails – and three chess apps. He doesn't play chess! ♟️

4 True or false? listening 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	Jack's keys were next to the milk.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
2	The Los Angeles study looked mainly at how messy the homes really were.	T	F	⏱️ 2:38
3	Normally, cortisol is higher in the morning and goes down during the day.	T	F	⏱️ 3:48
4	People from the tidy room were more likely to choose an apple.	T	F	⏱️ 5:34
5	Lucy says a perfect, magazine-style home is the goal.	T	F	⏱️ 6:52
6	Jack says a messy home always means a person is lazy.	T	F	⏱️ 6:52



5 Three studies 🔍 listening 6 points

Which study is each sentence about? Write **A**, **B** or **C**. ⏱️ 2:38 · 4:48 · 5:34

A · Los Angeles 🏠
2010 · homes, words and stress hormones

B · Princeton 🧠
brain scientists · objects and attention

C · Minnesota 🏓
2013 · tidy room vs messy room

1	People in a messy room had more creative ideas for ping pong balls.	☐
2	Lots of objects in front of us compete for our attention.	☐
3	Women who described their homes as cluttered had a flatter cortisol pattern.	☐
4	People from a tidy room were more likely to give money to charity.	☐
5	Researchers studied the words people used on a video tour of their home.	☐
6	A messy desk is like trying to listen to someone in a noisy room.	☐



6 Link or proof? new! think like a scientist 4 points

The Los Angeles study found a **link** between clutter and stress – not **proof**. Is each sentence fair to say, or too strong? ⏱️ 3:48

1. "Clutter causes stress – science has proved it!"
☐ ✓ FAIR TO SAY ☐ × TOO STRONG

2. "Clutter and stress seem to be connected."
☐ ✓ FAIR TO SAY ☐ × TOO STRONG

3. "Everyone with a messy home is stressed."
☐ ✓ FAIR TO SAY ☐ × TOO STRONG

4. "Maybe stressed people find it harder to tidy."
☐ ✓ FAIR TO SAY ☐ × TOO STRONG

✏️ **Bonus** (no points): make this headline fair. *"MESSY HOMES MAKE YOU ILL!"* → _____

7 "It's a complete mess!" listening 10 points



Two flatmates on a Saturday morning. Listen at ⏱ 11:53 and write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer A and B. The breakdown at ⏱ 12:56 can help.

JACK
Morning. What's all this? Why are there 1 _____ bags everywhere?



LUCY
I've decided. Today we're going to 2 _____ up the living room. It's a complete 3 _____.

JACK
Today? But it's Saturday.



LUCY
I know, but I can't relax with all this clutter. There's 4 _____ everywhere. Look at that pile of magazines.

JACK
Fair enough. Those are mine, I suppose. I'll go 5 _____ them and get 6 _____ of the old ones.



LUCY
Great. And can you put your shoes 7 _____? They're in the middle of the floor again.

JACK
Okay, okay. What about all these cables?



LUCY
Let's 8 _____ them out. If we don't know what they're for, we throw them out.

JACK
Wait, that one's important. I think.



LUCY
You said that last time. Okay, let's give it twenty minutes and then have a coffee.

JACK
Deal. Actually, this already feels better.

A. Jack's **one word** for "OK, I agree!": _____

B. Americans call **bin bags**… _____

💡 Away, down or on? small words · no points

One verb, three meanings! Listen for these at ⏱ 12:56 and ⏱ 16:15.

👟 ➜ 🗄️
Put your shoes away.
Put them in their proper place.

👟 ⬇️
Put your shoes down.
Just place them somewhere.

👟 🚶
Put your shoes on.
Wear them – we're going out!

🎭 **Say it out loud!** Play both parts – then talk about **your** living room: what would you sort out first?

8 Tidying phrasal verbs

new! small words, big difference · 8 points



Complete each sentence with a word from the box. Some are used twice. ⏱ 12:56 · 16:15

away · on · out · rid · through · up

1. Let's tidy _____ the living room before our friends arrive.
2. Can you put your shoes _____? They're in the middle of the floor.
3. I'll go _____ these old magazines and keep the good ones.
4. I finally got _____ of my old sofa.
5. We don't know what these cables are for. Let's throw them _____.
6. Don't throw your old books in the bin – give them _____ to someone who needs them.
7. These cables are a mess. Let's sort them _____.
8. Put your shoes _____ – it's raining and we're going out!



Jack's tip: With **it** or **them**, the small word goes at the **end**: *"Throw it away."* ✓ · *"Put them away."* ✓ – not *"throw away it"* ×.

9 Clean or tidy? + home jobs

new! collocations · 6 points

Clean = remove dirt and dust. **Tidy** = put things in order. Write **clean** or **tidy** (1–3), then **make**, **do** or **take** (4–6). ⏱ 16:15

1. 📄 Papers everywhere? I need to _____ my desk.
2. 🧽 The floor is sticky. I need to _____ it.
3. 🪶 Dust on every shelf? Time to _____ them!
4. 🛏️ Every morning I _____ the bed.
5. 🍽️ We _____ the washing-up.
6. 🗑️ Can you _____ out the rubbish?

🌳 Word family

bonus · no points

Change the word in CAPITALS so it fits the sentence. ⏱ 13:51

a) My desk is very _____. **(CLUTTER)**
b) His room is always _____. **(MESS)**
c) My plans are a _____. **(MESSY)**
d) There are books about _____. **(DECLUTTER)**

🎨 Tidy desk or a bit of mess?

think · no points

It depends on what you need! Tick the better space for each job. ⏱ 5:34 · 6:52

1. 📖 studying for a test — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy
2. 💡 brainstorming ideas — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy
3. ⏰ a new morning routine — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy
4. 🖌️ painting a picture — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy
5. 🍎 choosing a healthy snack — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy
6. ♻️ new uses for old things — ☐ 🧘 tidy ☐ 🎨 messy

10 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 16:15

😐 1. "I will collect my room." 😊 _____

😐 2. "My room is very complex." 😊 _____

😐 3. "I threw the old clothes." (into the bin) 😊 _____

😐 4. "Put your shoes." (in the cupboard) 😊 _____

😐 5. "There are many things everywhere." 😊 _____



Lucy's tip: "Tidy" is very British. In American English, people often say **"neat"** (a neat room) or **"clean up"** (clean up your room). Both are fine!



11 Tidy sayings

expressions · 4 points

Match each expression (1–4) to its meaning (a–d). ⏱️ 8:01 · 13:51

☐ **1.** "It looks like a bomb's hit it!"

☐ **2.** "A place for everything, and everything in its place."

☐ **3.** "One in, one out."

☐ **4.** the five-minute rule

a) an old saying about being organised
b) tidy one small area for five minutes – then you can stop
c) a place is extremely messy
d) when something new comes home, an old thing goes



🗂️ Keep, give away or throw out?

your choice · no points

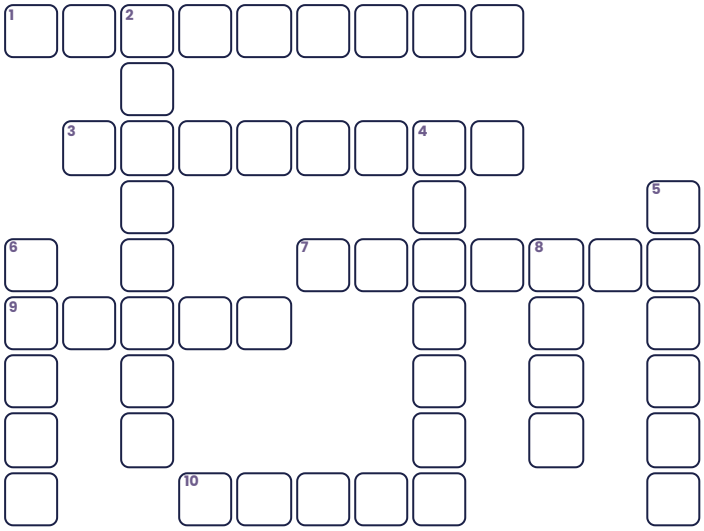
There's no wrong answer! Decide, then say it out loud: *"I'd keep the book."* · *"I'd give away the jumper."*

Tick one box for each thing	💚 KEEP	💙 GIVE AWAY	🗑️ THROW OUT
👕 a jumper you haven't worn for three years	☐	☐	☐
🔌 a cable – nobody knows what it's for	☐	☐	☐
📚 a book you loved, but won't read again	☐	☐	☐
🧸 a toy from your childhood	☐	☐	☐
🎫 two old train tickets	☐	☐	☐
🎂 a birthday card from your best friend	☐	☐	☐

12 Tidy-up crossword 🧩 puzzle 10 points



Read the clues and write the words in the grid (1 point each). The number in brackets is the number of letters. Letters that cross help you!



➡️ Across

1 To remove things you don't need: "I'm going to ___ my wardrobe." (9)

3 People in the messy room had more ___ ideas. (8)

7 Piles of paper, old bags and things on every surface: ___. (7)

9 At the cooking class, Lucy learned to make fresh ___. (5)

10 Lucy's ___ was covered in clothes for about three weeks. (5)

⬇️ Down

2 A stress hormone that is normally higher in the morning. (8)

4 Lucy's brother gave her a ___ for a cooking class. (7)

5 Jack found his keys in the ___, next to the milk. (6)

6 People from the tidy room were more likely to choose an ___. (5)

8 Jack had thirty-one ___ open on his laptop. (4)



13 The chair story 🪑 listening 6 points

Listen at ⏱️ 18:39. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

☐ 💌 At the very bottom, she found an unopened envelope.

☐ 🎂 At a busy birthday dinner in August, Lucy's brother gave her an envelope.

☐ 📞 She called her brother to say thank you.

☐ 🧥 She put it in her jacket pocket, and the jacket went on the chair.

☐ 🍰 She booked the cooking class – it expired the next Saturday!

☐ 🪑 Last Saturday, Lucy finally cleared the chair.

Think about it 💭 (no points) Why did Lucy's brother think she hated his present?

14 Your turn

writing · 8 points

2 points for each good sentence.



A. Five minutes later... 🔍

Tidy one drawer or shelf for five minutes. What did you find? What did you get rid of? *e.g. "I found two old train tickets in the back of a drawer."*

B. My study space plan 📚

How will you get your desk ready in two minutes? *e.g. "Before I study, I'll put everything else in a box."*



⏱️ My five-minute week

your 7-day mission

Set a timer for five minutes each day. When it stops, you can stop!

Day	Area	What I found or got rid of	Done?
1	🗄️ one drawer		☐
2	🖥️ my desk		☐
3	📱 my phone's home screen		☐
4	🪑 "the chair"		☐
5	👜 my bag		☐
6	📚 one shelf		☐
7	✉️ the letter pile		☐

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🧹 TIDY UP
Let's tidy up.
Put it away, please.
Let's sort it out.

🗑️ GET RID OF
throw it away / out
give it away
I got rid of...

😱 WHAT A MESS!
It's a complete mess.
There's stuff everywhere.
A bomb's hit it!

✨ RULES
the five-minute rule
a place for everything
one in, one out

Can you do it now?

I can...	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain what clutter can do to stress and focus.	😟	🙂	😄
use tidy up, put away, get rid of and sort out.	😟	🙂	😄
explain the difference between clean and tidy.	😟	🙂	😄
say when a study shows a link, not proof.	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! Give one small area five minutes – then tell us in the comments what you found! Use **"I finally got rid of..."** or **"I found... in the back of a drawer."** And do you have "the chair" too? 🪑💜

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Guess: b – in one study, people in a messy room had more creative ideas. · Predict: **umbrella** ☂️ isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 c · 2 g · 3 j · 4 e · 5 d · 6 h · 7 b · 8 a · 9 i · 10 f
Big idea: b (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 a · 2 b · 3 c · 4 a · 5 b · 6 b · 7 a · 8 b · 9 c · 10 b

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (how people described their homes) · 3 T · 4 T · 5 F (a perfect home isn't the goal) · 6 F (it's not because people are lazy)

5 · Three studies · 6 · Link or proof?

5: 1 C · 2 B · 3 A · 4 C · 5 A · 6 B
6: 1 too strong · 2 fair to say · 3 too strong · 4 fair to say
Bonus, e.g.: "Messy homes may be linked to stress."

7 · "It's a complete mess!"

1 bin · 2 tidy · 3 mess · 4 stuff · 5 through · 6 rid · 7 away · 8 sort · A Deal! · B trash bags

8 · Tidying phrasal verbs

1 up · 2 away · 3 through · 4 rid · 5 out (away is also correct) · 6 away · 7 out · 8 on

11 · Tidy sayings

1 c · 2 a · 3 d · 4 b

9 · Clean or tidy? + home jobs

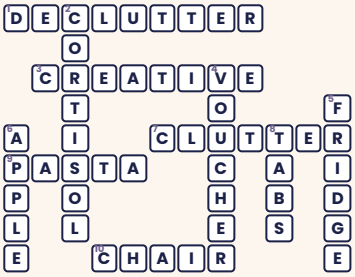
1 tidy · 2 clean · 3 clean · 4 make · 5 do · 6 take
Word family: a cluttered · b messy · c mess · d decluttering
Tidy or mess? 1 tidy · 2 mess · 3 tidy · 4 mess · 5 tidy · 6 mess

10 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 I'm going to tidy my room. / I'm going to tidy up. · 2 My room is really messy / untidy. · 3 I threw away my old clothes. / I threw out… / I gave away… · 4 Put your shoes away. · 5 There's stuff everywhere.

12 · Crossword

Across: 1 declutter · 3 creative · 7 clutter · 9 pasta · 10 chair
Down: 2 cortisol · 4 voucher · 5 fridge · 6 apple · 8 tabs



13 · The chair story · 14 · Your turn

1 🎂 birthday dinner · 2 🧥 jacket on the chair · 3 🪑 cleared the chair · 4 💌 the envelope · 5 🍝 booked the class · 6 📞 called her brother
Think about it: she never mentioned it for two months – the envelope was lost on the chair!
14: your own answers – 2 points per good sentence.

Your score

90–100 🏆 **Tidy genius!** · 70–89 ✨ **Everything in its place** · 50–69 🧹 **Tidying up** · 0–49 🪑 **Still under the chair – listen again!**

Enjoyed this worksheet? 🎉
Scan to subscribe to **Daily Speak English** – new episodes with Jack and Lucy every week. And give one small corner five minutes this week! 🧹
More free worksheets: **dailyspeakenglish.github.io/worksheets**



Free for personal and classroom use. Please share the page link, not the file.